

This way the government won't be able to take the public for granted.

V.K. NAIR, *Mumbai*

Wily Old Man

For setting aside 12 conditions for BJP and even then refusing to support them, former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda deserves a trophy. He is the biggest betrayer the country has seen in recent times ("On a Wish and a Prayer", November 26).

RAMESH AGARWAL, *Kanpur*

It is now up to the people of Karnataka to give a befitting reply to politicians like Gowda who have time and again displayed their hunger for power while claiming they have no need for it.

M.M. KALE, *on e-mail*

Gowda deserves the Bharat Ratna for the scant respect he has shown to democratic principles. Not that other politicians are better in adhering to these principles, but no one can beat him in abusing the Constitution.

K.R.P. GUPTA, *on e-mail*

War and Piece

Instead of bidding farewell to war heroes through ceremonial salutes, the nation should provide their families adequate compensation and take care of their well-being ("A Farewell to the Fallen", November 26). It should be on par with the remuneration that cricketers get.

MADHU AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

Captain Perfect

Legendary leg spinner Anil Kumble deserves the captaincy ("It's His Turn",

November 26). He is the third highest wicket taker in the world and has been consistent with the ball throughout his career. He is the country's pride.

K. PRADEEP, *Chennai*

The Shame

The *Tehelka* sting operation has confirmed yet again what was suspected all along—fanatics went on a rampage in Gujarat, maiming not only the anatomy but the psyche of the people as well (Sins of

Silence", November 12). The exposé has brought the skeletons out in the open. By protecting the murderers, Chief Minister Narendra Modi has even shamed the devil.

VASUDHA P. RAO, *on e-mail*

Correction

The name of former USSR president Mikhail Gorbachev was wrongly given as Michael Gorbachev in "Why Buddha is not Smiling" (November 19). The error is regretted.

GENERAL THOUGHTS



General Pervez Musharraf might be falling deeper into the pit he has ironically dug for himself but there is at least one thing which is common between India and Pakistan—both have a vibrant judiciary ("Why He will Not Last", November 19).

ANJUM M. SAMEL, *Mumbai*

It is obvious that the General put himself before anyone else though he attributes his action to the good of the country. To ease the situation, he should step aside, apologise and accept the people's verdict.

MADHU R.D. SINGH, *Ambala*

Musharraf has a choice. He can either pull back Pakistan from the brink of a disaster, or become a footnote of the country's uninspiring history as yet another general who grabbed power for self-aggrandisement.

J. SESHAGIRI, *Mysore*

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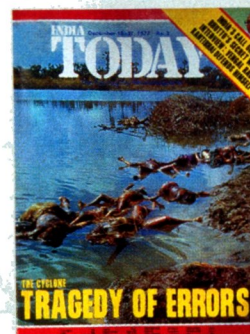
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Years Ago in India Today

DECEMBER 16-30, 1977



An Area of Darkness

The first signs of the cyclone became evident less than a mile outside the city. All along the road from the towns of Vijayawada to Avanigadda in Andhra Pradesh, the carcasses of giant tamarind trees and stunted telegraph poles pock-marked an otherwise peaceful landscape. But the coconut palms had withstood the storm.



In the village of Kuchipudi, a villager said, "It was not bad here. You must go beyond Avanigadda. You will be lucky if you see any living humans." St Ann's hospital in Avanigadda was transformed into a shelter for the hundreds of refugees, some clutching a few belongings, others dragging half-dead children and relations. They were the survivors. In cold print and in terms of functional journalistic copy, the scale of the disaster and the magnitude of devastation tend to become a cruel game of numbers.

—Sunil Sethi